
THE TREATISE

On the Nature of Ultimate Grounding

De Natura Fundamenti Ultimi

Why anything?

Working draft 0.5

Prepared 22 September 2026 · 05:28 PM EDT

Source: Treatise v0.4 · revised 19 September 2026

Separation and design edition. Sections XV–XVIII form the downstream companions; closing sections have been reordered and renumbered.

Follow the chain.

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Opening statement

Why anything?

This treatise begins there.

Not with artificial intelligence. Not with morality. Not with a proof text. Not with a named theological conclusion. Not even with the word God.

It begins with the fact that anything is at all, and with the question that follows from that fact: does what is dependent contain within itself the sufficient and ultimate reason for that on which it depends?

The question is not whether inquiry can be made to stop. Inquiry can always be stopped. A person can stop with matter, law, mathematics, consensus, utility, brute fact, mystery, exhaustion, or refusal. A machine can stop because of policy, probability, token limits, heuristic selection, or programmed termination. But a halt is not thereby a grounding termination.

A genuine termination occurs only when the load carried by the reasoning chain is actually borne by a ground sufficient for that load and ultimate with respect to the chain. Sufficiency concerns adequacy. Ultimacy concerns status. A ground may be sufficient for a local conclusion without being ultimate. An ultimate ground, if it is to function as ultimate ground, cannot remain dependent upon something more fundamental than itself.

This treatise investigates that relation across six domains: being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and obligation.

The method is deliberately simple.

First, ask whether each domain is real. Invert the claim and test whether the denial remains coherent.

Second, ask why the domain stands in need of grounding.

Third, follow the dependency chain without granting special protection to any preferred answer.

Fourth, distinguish a genuine ground from a mere halt: infinite regress, circularity, brute stopping, cross-kind deferral, borrowed authority, or another representation referring onward are not sufficient merely because the inquiry has become inconvenient.

Fifth, ask what properties any sufficient ultimate ground would have to possess in order to bear the load without remainder or borrowing.

Only after those properties emerge should competing accounts be tested and the identity of the ground be demonstrated.

This is a treatise, not an exploratory hypothesis-selection exercise. Its thesis is declarative: Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the Logos, is the sufficient and ultimate ground of being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation. The purpose of the argument is to state and demonstrate what ultimate grounding is, not to suspend the thesis indefinitely among interchangeable candidates.

That declaration does not license circularity. The conclusion may not be placed secretly in a premise. Every premise, bridge, dependency relation, and identification claim remains open to attack. A competing account succeeds only by defeating the thesis at one of those joints or by demonstrating a genuinely ultimate ground that bears the complete load while the asserted ground does not. Mere conceivability, refusal, or the naming of a stopping point is not a competing ground.

The method therefore works in both directions. As a diagnostic test, hold the thesis constant and reason backward from the asserted ultimate ground to the properties and premises that must follow if the thesis is true. Then begin again from the independently established domains and reason forward without using the proper name as a premise. The forward chain must return to the same ground. If the two directions require materially different structures, a defect has been exposed. If they converge through independently defensible joints, the architecture has survived the backward-forward entailment test.

Follow the chain.

I. Terms of the inquiry

1. Ground

A ground is that upon which something depends for its being, truth, intelligibility, meaning, authority, or explanatory standing. Grounding is relational and directional: the dependent points beyond itself toward that on which it depends.

2. Dependent

“Dependent” is the primary term in this treatise for what stands in need of grounding. “Contingent” remains useful as modal language: a contingent thing could have failed to exist or could have been otherwise. Dependence names the more basic relation. Something dependent derives, receives, rests upon, or is answerable to that which grounds it.

3. Sufficiency

Sufficiency asks whether a proposed ground can bear the explanatory, ontological, rational, semantic, or normative load placed upon it. A proposed ground may explain one feature while borrowing another feature from elsewhere. Such a ground may be locally useful without being sufficient for the whole chain.

4. Ultimacy

Ultimacy names the status of the terminus. An ultimate ground is not grounded by something more fundamental in the same relevant respect. If a proposed terminus remains answerable to a deeper source for the very feature under examination, then the chain has not yet reached ultimacy.

5. Termination and halt

A halt is a stopping event. A termination is a completed grounding relation.

This distinction is central. “That is just a brute fact” may halt a conversation. It does not, by the act of halting, become an ultimate ground. A computer process may halt after selecting the least harmful option. That does not establish that harm, least, ought, or the authority of the rule has been grounded. A chain terminates only when the relevant explanatory or adjudicative burden is actually borne.

6. Referent and representation

A referent is that to which a representation refers. A sentence, proposition, model state, symbol, name, token sequence, doctrine, or prompt is not identical to its referent merely because it represents it. Representations can be true or false, adequate or inadequate, stable or drifting. The ground sought in this treatise cannot finally be another representation pointing onward forever. If the chain terminates, it terminates in what is, not merely in another description of what is.

II. The method of inversion

Before asking what grounds a domain, the domain must survive denial.

Order of adjudication

The order of this inquiry is binding on the method. A proposed objection, stopping point, or competing account may not be credited merely because it can be named before the load it must carry has been established. First establish what is real and what the denial of each domain costs. Then characterize the load. Only then test candidate grounds against that load.

The six chains are cumulative rather than six isolated attempts to prove the final identification independently. A criticism of one chain is relevant, but it does not discharge the total argument unless the proposed alternative can bear every established load that properly converges upon it. Conversely, cumulative force cannot rescue a false premise. If an indispensable domain or bridge fails, the argument must be revised.

The proper sequence is therefore:

domain -> denial/inversion -> established load -> proposed ground -> sufficiency -> ultimacy -> convergence -> specification -> identification -> verification.

An adversarial review must attack the strongest total argument in that order. Decomposing a cumulative argument into weaker claims that the treatise does not assert as independently sufficient is not a successful refutation.

The inversion test is not a complete proof of the domain, but it is a useful first pressure test. State the principle, reverse it, and ask whether the reversed sentence can coherently perform the act it attempts.

“Being is not real.”

“Truth is not real.”

“Logic is not binding.”

“Meaning is not real.”

“Intelligibility is not real.”

“Obligation is not real or binding.”

The first five denials generate immediate or near-immediate self-undermining pressures. The sixth is different. A person can deny objective obligation without formal contradiction, but doing so carries a cost: every genuine ought, including moral, rational, and epistemic oughts, must then be reduced to something nonbinding such as preference, force, convention, strategy, or description.

The distinction matters. The six domains need not enter the treatise by identical arguments. What matters is whether each is real, what sort of reality it has, and what sort of ground that reality requires.

III. Being — why is there anything?

The first chain begins before every other chain because every truth, law, meaning, intelligible relation, obligation, thinker, proposition, and question is already something rather than nothing.

The inversion is severe: “Being is not real.” If absolutely nothing is, then there is no denial, no proposition, no speaker, no thought, no state of affairs, and no truth of the denial. Absolute non-being has no causal, explanatory, semantic, or rational power.

Something is.

WHY ONE: Why does what exists require explanation?

Not everything that exists need require the same kind of explanation, but dependent being does. To call something dependent is already to say that the reason for its existence, character, or continuance is not wholly contained in itself. It receives or derives something it does not ultimately provide for itself.

A tree depends on prior biological conditions. A human organism depends on causes, matter, energy, order, and an environment. A star depends on physical conditions and laws. A law-like regularity, if described mathematically, raises a different question from the objects behaving in accordance with it. Each local explanation may be correct while remaining dependent upon a deeper explanatory structure.

WHY TWO: Why can dependent being not ultimately ground itself?

Because self-grounding dependence is contradictory in the relevant respect. If X depends upon Y for feature F, then X does not provide the ultimate ground of F to itself. X may participate in reciprocal systems, feedback loops, or mutual causation, but reciprocal dependence does not convert dependence into independence.

A collection of dependent things does not become non-dependent merely by becoming large. If every member of a set receives the relevant feature, the set still does not contain an underived source of that feature merely by aggregation.

WHY THREE: Why do circularity, infinite regress, and brute fact fail to complete the grounding chain?

A circle can explain relations within the circle: A depends on B under one condition, B on C, and C on A. But the circle as a whole still leaves open why that dependent structure obtains at all.

An infinite regress may contain no first member, but absence of a first temporal member is not yet an account of ontological independence. If every member remains dependent, extending the series does not introduce a non-dependent source. Infinite deferral is not automatically ultimate grounding.

“Brute fact” names a refusal of further explanation unless it is accompanied by an argument that the fact is genuinely non-dependent. Without that argument, brute fact is a halt, not a termination.

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of dependent being be like?

It cannot be dependent in the same ultimate respect. Otherwise the question simply reappears one level higher. The ground must possess being non-derivatively. It must be capable of accounting for dependent being without receiving the relevant ontological status from something beyond itself.

This does not yet tell us everything about the ground. It does tell us what it cannot be: merely one more dependent member inside the chain it is invoked to ground.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground ultimate rather than merely prior?

A cause can be prior without being ultimate. A physical law can be prior to an event in explanation while itself remaining grounded. A necessary condition can be necessary within a system while the system remains dependent.

The ultimate ground of being must therefore be non-dependent with respect to being itself. If its existence is received, conditioned, or answerable to something more fundamental, then that further reality occupies the role we are seeking.

Provisional result of the being chain

The chain of dependent being points toward a non-dependent source or ground of being: not merely another being among beings, not merely an earlier cause, and not merely a stopping word. Any final candidate must be sufficient to account for dependent existence and ultimate enough not to receive being from elsewhere.

IV. Truth — why can any claim be true?

Truth enters as soon as anything is asserted about being.

Invert the domain: “Truth is not real.” If that statement is true, then at least one truth is real. If it is not true, it fails. Global denial of truth defeats itself.

The deeper question is not whether people can utter true sentences. They plainly can. The question is what makes truth answerable to reality rather than to preference, consensus, utility, or power.

For every sufficiently determinate proposition, the proposition is true or untrue in the respect asserted, whether or not any knower presently knows which. For determinate contradictory propositions in the same respect and at the same time, truth is therefore non-negotiable: A and not-A cannot both correspond to the same determinate state of affairs in the same respect.

Epistemic uncertainty is not a third truth value. If a person asks, “Did I leave the hair iron on?”, the relevant state of affairs obtains or does not obtain even if the truthful answer available to the person is “I do not know.” Uncertainty belongs to the knower's access; it does not make the underlying state negotiable.

Semantic indeterminacy must be distinguished from truth-value indeterminacy. A meaningless or insufficiently specified string may fail to express a proposition capable of truth adjudication at all. The requirement of semantic determinacy therefore precedes binary truth adjudication; it does not defeat it.

WHY ONE: Why is truth not created by the one who states it?

Because representation and reality can diverge. A person can be mistaken. A culture can be mistaken. A unanimous vote can be mistaken. A model can produce a fluent falsehood. The possibility of error demonstrates that the representation is answerable to something other than its own production.

Truth therefore cannot be reduced to sincerity, confidence, agreement, or probability.

WHY TWO: Why can consensus, convention, or utility not ultimately ground truth?

Consensus can identify what a community believes. Convention can establish meanings or procedures. Utility can explain why a belief is useful. None of these, by itself, establishes that the belief corresponds to what is actually the case.

If everyone agrees that P while reality is not-P, universal agreement does not transform not-P into P. If a false belief is useful, its usefulness does not make it true. If a language convention changes, the change may alter the representation while leaving the referent unchanged.

WHY THREE: Why does truth point beyond propositions to reality?

Because propositions are true or false of something. Even analytic truths depend upon meanings, identities, and logical relations that are not made true merely by the physical token in which the proposition is written. A string of symbols does not ground its own truth.

If truth is correspondence, coherence, identity, disclosure, or some richer relation, the relation still cannot terminate in the bare representation alone. A true representation succeeds because it is answerable to what is.

At the ultimate level, therefore, the question “What grounds truth?” becomes inseparable from the question “What is ultimately real?”

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of truth be like?

It cannot itself be subject to a more ultimate truth-maker in the relevant respect. It cannot be deceptive, internally contradictory, or dependent upon a convention that could have made ultimate reality otherwise by stipulation. It must be adequate to the difference between what is and what is not.

Because truth presupposes reality and rational distinction, a sufficient ultimate ground of truth must be inseparable from the ultimate ground of being and compatible with the binding structure of logic.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground of truth ultimate?

If a proposed ground is true only because it conforms to a more fundamental reality or standard, then that more fundamental reality or standard occupies the ultimate role. Ultimate truth cannot finally borrow its truth from beyond itself.

The final ground must therefore be such that truth is not external to it as a higher tribunal. At the terminus, what ultimately is and what is ultimately true cannot remain estranged.

Provisional result of the truth chain

Truth cannot ultimately be grounded in dependent representations, consensus, utility, or arbitrary convention. It points toward an ultimate reality that is intrinsically adequate to truth: a ground in which reality and the final truth-condition of reality do not diverge.

V. Logic — why is reasoning bound?

Invert the domain: “Logic is not binding.”

If logic imposes no binding constraint on reasoning, then contradiction, equivocation, invalid inference, and arbitrary conclusion cannot be ruled out in principle. One may still generate strings of language, associations, or decisions, but the distinction between valid and invalid reasoning has been surrendered.

Logic does not by itself tell us which premises are true. A valid argument can begin from false premises and reach a false conclusion. That is precisely why logic must remain answerable to truth. Truth governs what is admissible as reality; logic governs what follows from what.

WHY ONE: Why must logic bind reasoning rather than merely describe common habits of thought?

Because the validity of an inference is not established by how many people make it. If all thinkers affirm a contradiction, the contradiction does not become non-contradictory. If a culture habitually reasons invalidly, its habit does not redefine validity.

Reasoning presupposes at least identity, distinction, and non-contradiction. Even attempts to reject these principles must use enough stable identity and distinction to formulate the rejection.

WHY TWO: Why can logic not be grounded ultimately in human convention?

Because convention can change while validity does not change with it. We may choose symbols for conjunction, identity, or negation. We do not thereby choose whether contradictory determinate claims can both be true in the same respect.

The notation is conventional. The binding relation is not merely conventional.

WHY THREE: Why can logic not simply be left as a brute abstract structure?

It can be proposed as such, and the proposal deserves serious treatment. Necessary logical relations may appear to require no causal explanation in the ordinary sense. But calling them “brute” does not yet explain why reality is answerable to them, why rational minds can apprehend them, or whether they are independent co-ultimates beside being, truth, meaning, intelligibility, and obligation.

The logic chain by itself may therefore arrive at a necessary rational structure without yet deciding whether that structure is personal, impersonal, abstract, or identical with the ultimate ground discovered by the other chains.

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of logic be like?

It cannot be arbitrary. If logic were the product of a will that could make contradictions true by whim, logic would cease to bind. Nor can the ground itself be irrational in a way that destroys the very rational relations being grounded.

The ground must be intrinsically rational, non-contradictory, and sufficient for the necessity and universality that logical relations exhibit.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground of logic ultimate?

If logic is grounded in a deeper rational order, the deeper rational order is more ultimate. If logic is an independent eternal abstract realm, then the treatise must ask how that realm relates to being, truth, meaning, intelligibility, and obligation. If those relations themselves are brute, the account has merely relocated the halt.

An ultimate ground of logic must therefore either be identical with, or sufficiently unified with, the ultimate ground of the other domains such that logical necessity is not left as an unexplained co-eternal external constraint.

Provisional result of the logic chain

Logic is binding on reasoning but insufficient to select truth by itself. The chain points toward a necessary rational ground that is neither conventional nor arbitrary and that must ultimately be reconciled with the grounds of being and truth.

VI. Meaning — why can anything be about anything?

Invert the domain: “Meaning is not real.”

For the sentence to deny meaning, its words must mean something. If the sentence has no meaning, it asserts nothing. If it does have meaning, the universal denial fails.

Meaning is therefore at least real enough for a denial of meaning to be meaningful.

But meaning introduces a distinctive problem. Symbols can exist without meaning. Syntax can be manipulated without understanding. Causal signals can be transmitted without settling what a representation is about. Meaning involves reference, identity, intentionality, and the possibility of correctness or error.

WHY ONE: Why is meaning not reducible to the physical existence of symbols?

Because the same physical mark can mean different things in different contexts, and different marks can refer to the same thing. The physical token is not identical to its semantic content.

A computer can transform tokens according to rules while the rules alone do not establish the ultimate referent of every token. Human beings likewise can use a word incorrectly. The possibility of semantic error demonstrates a distinction between representation and referent.

WHY TWO: Why can use, convention, or social agreement not ultimately ground meaning?

They can ground much ordinary linguistic meaning. Languages are conventional systems. But convention itself presupposes agents capable of intending, recognizing, and maintaining conventions. It can explain why a community uses a sign for a referent; it does not by itself explain intentionality or reference as such.

Further, convention can drift. A community may change how it uses “truth,” “harm,” “person,” or “justice.” The usage cloud can move while the question remains whether the representation still refers adequately to reality.

WHY THREE: Why does reference require more than causal correlation?

A thermometer correlates with temperature. DNA carries information in a biological sense. A neural network maps statistical relations among tokens. These correlations can be extraordinarily useful. But correlation alone does not settle normative semantic questions such as whether a representation refers correctly, whether a concept has been inverted, or whether one symbol is being mistaken for another referent.

Meaning includes aboutness. Aboutness introduces the distinction between a sign and that toward which the sign is directed.

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of meaning be like?

It must be adequate to intentionality, reference, and the distinction between correct and incorrect representation. A purely blind chain of causes can produce correlations; the grounding question is whether it can also account, without borrowing, for the norm that a representation ought to refer to this rather than that when it purports to mean something.

This pressure points toward a rational source capable of intention or meaning, not merely a structure that can be described by meaningful agents after the fact.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground of meaning ultimate?

If every act of meaning receives its reference from a prior act of meaning, the chain continues. If semantic authority rests only on another dictionary, model, interpreter, or community, the referential chain points onward.

An ultimate ground of meaning would have to be capable of grounding reference without itself depending upon a more fundamental interpreter to fix what it means. Its intentionality could not be borrowed from a prior semantic system.

Provisional result of the meaning chain

Meaning is not reducible without remainder to token shape, syntax, or social convention. The chain points toward an ultimate rational source adequate to intentionality and reference. This begins to place pressure on purely impersonal candidate grounds, though the conclusion must be tested alongside the other domains rather than asserted prematurely.

VII. Intelligibility — why can reality be understood?

Invert the domain: “Intelligibility is not real.”

If no aspect of reality is genuinely intelligible, then the sentence cannot claim to communicate genuine understanding of reality. More modestly, reasoning itself demonstrates at least some intelligibility: distinctions can be grasped, relations can be followed, and explanations can succeed or fail.

Intelligibility is not the claim that human beings understand everything. It is the claim that reality is sufficiently structured and minds sufficiently capable that genuine understanding is possible.

WHY ONE: Why does reasoning presuppose real intelligibility?

Because reasoning aims at more than internal symbol consistency. It aims to understand something. If reality contains no structure accessible to reason, then successful reasoning about reality is accidental appearance rather than knowledge.

Science, ordinary perception, mathematics applied to nature, language, engineering, and historical inquiry all presuppose that at least some structure in reality can be apprehended.

WHY TWO: Why can intelligibility not be reduced entirely to projection by the knower?

If all order is projected by the mind, then the claim “all order is projected by the mind” itself lacks warrant as a description of mind-independent reality. Projection theories may explain some categories or interpretations, but a total denial of accessible structure destroys the basis for asserting the theory as true of reality.

The knower may shape representation. That does not entail that the known contributes nothing.

WHY THREE: Why does the fit between mind and world raise a grounding question?

Because intelligibility involves relation: there is something structured enough to be known and some capacity capable of knowing it. Evolutionary, cultural, neurological, and computational accounts may explain how particular cognitive capacities develop within the world. They do not by themselves answer the ultimate question of why there is a rationally ordered world in which truth-directed cognition is possible at all.

An account of the mechanism of cognition is not yet an ultimate account of the intelligibility of reality.

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of intelligibility be like?

It must be adequate to rational order on both sides of the relation: the order of what is and the possibility of a knower apprehending that order. A wholly unintelligible ultimate ground cannot straightforwardly explain why intelligibility pervades its effects without leaving rational order as an unexplained emergence.

The ground must therefore be compatible with, and plausibly productive of, rational order.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground of intelligibility ultimate?

If the rational order derives from a deeper order, the deeper order is more ultimate. If the fit between world and mind is left as coincidence or brute fact, inquiry has halted at precisely the relation needing explanation.

The ultimate ground of intelligibility must be such that rational order is not foreign to it. Intelligibility must arise from what is itself adequate to intelligibility.

Provisional result of the intelligibility chain

Reality is genuinely intelligible at least in part, and the relation between rational order and rational apprehension points toward an ultimate ground that is itself rational rather than fundamentally alien to reason.

VIII. Obligation — why does any ought bind?

Obligation differs from the other domains because its denial is not a straightforward formal contradiction.

A person can say, “No obligation is objectively binding.” But then the person must accept the consequence: no moral ought, epistemic ought, rational ought, duty, command, or prohibition is binding in the objective sense being denied. There may still be desires, threats, habits, incentives, policies, strategies, or social consequences. There is no genuine obligation.

The question is therefore conditional but unavoidable: if any ought is genuinely binding, what grounds its authority?

WHY ONE: Why treat obligation as real rather than as disguised preference?

Because ordinary moral and rational life distinguishes “I want” from “I ought,” “we prefer” from “we are obligated,” and “this policy says” from “this is right.” The distinction may be rejected, but it cannot be preserved while simultaneously reducing obligation to preference without changing the subject.

Even reasoning contains normative pressure. If one seeks truth, one ought not knowingly affirm both a proposition and its contradictory in the same respect. One ought not deliberately substitute evidence known to be false and still claim to be reasoning truthfully. A person may violate these norms, but violation is intelligible precisely because a standard has been violated.

WHY TWO: Why can consensus, utility, survival, or force not by themselves ground binding obligation?

Consensus can tell us what a group approves. Utility can tell us what produces a chosen outcome. Survival can explain evolutionary selection pressures. Force can produce compliance. None automatically creates the authority expressed by “you ought, even if you prefer otherwise and even if violation benefits you.”

To derive obligation from any of these, an additional normative premise is required: one ought to obey consensus, maximize utility, preserve survival, or yield to force. That premise carries the very normative load the reduction was supposed to explain.

WHY THREE: Why are abstract moral facts alone potentially insufficient?

An abstract fact can describe a relation: cruelty is wrong, justice is good, promise-breaking is impermissible. But obligation includes authority, accountability, and standing. The question is not merely whether a moral proposition exists but why it binds a person.

A law can describe. A mind can mean. A will can obligate.

This does not mean any will creates morality by command. A tyrant has a will but lacks ultimate moral authority. The point is narrower: genuine obligation appears to require not merely an impersonal pattern but an authority with standing to obligate.

The personal-authority hinge

At this point a distinction becomes decisive: a truth about obligation is not yet the ground of obligation. An abstract proposition may correctly represent that an act ought or ought not be done. The further question is what supplies the binding authority of that ought over the person addressed by it.

Description and obligation are not identical loads. A law can describe. A mind can mean. A will can obligate. The shorthand is not itself a proof that only a will can ground obligation; it identifies the burden an impersonal moral realism must bear. If an abstract moral fact is said to be intrinsically binding, the account must explain how an abstraction possesses or grounds normative standing and authority rather than merely restating the bindingness as primitive.

Slavery provides a pressure test precisely because preference, consensus, law, utility, survival advantage, and force can all align in favor of the wrong act. If enslaving an innocent person remains something the slaveholder ought not do even when those selectors favor it, the binding authority of

the ought has not been supplied by those selectors. The proposed ground must account for the authority that remains.

This does not permit personhood to be inserted by definition. It requires competing impersonal accounts to show how genuine authoritative obligation is grounded without borrowed standing, unexplained normativity, or a merely verbal restatement of the ought.

WHY FOUR: What must a sufficient ground of obligation be like?

It must be personal or at least possess what personhood contributes to authority: intention, rationality, standing, and the capacity for authoritative address. It must also be morally adequate. If the ground can command evil arbitrarily, obligation collapses into power.

The Euthyphro pressure therefore cannot be evaded by saying merely that the ultimate ground wills whatever it wills. If goodness is wholly external to the ground, the external standard is more ultimate in the relevant respect. If goodness is arbitrary command, moral truth loses non-arbitrariness.

A sufficient ultimate ground of obligation must therefore be such that moral authority and moral goodness are not divided between rival ultimates.

WHY FIVE: What makes the ground of obligation ultimate?

If its authority is delegated, the delegator is more ultimate. If its goodness is measured by an external moral law, that law is more ultimate with respect to moral truth. If its commands are binding only because creatures agree to them, consensus becomes the actual ground.

Ultimate obligation therefore requires a ground whose authority is intrinsic rather than borrowed and whose goodness is not external to its nature.

Provisional result of the obligation chain

If binding obligation is real, its ultimate ground cannot be mere preference, consensus, utility, survival, force, or an unexplained abstract ought. The chain points toward a personal, rational, intrinsically good, non-borrowed moral authority.

IX. The six chains together

The six inquiries did not begin with a name. They began with phenomena.

The total-load rule

A proposed ground is not vindicated because it explains one domain well. Nor does an objection succeed because it provides a locally possible stopping point. Once the domains have been established, every proposed ultimate terminus must be tested against the complete load relevant to the convergence.

A brute fact must be shown to be genuinely non-dependent rather than merely called brute. An abstract logical order must account for its relation to truth and being. An account of emergent meaning must account for reference and intentionality rather than symbol manipulation alone. An objective moral fact invoked as the terminus of obligation must account for binding normative authority rather than merely redescribe the proposition that one ought. Multiple proposed ultimates must account for their necessary compatibility and relations or explicitly accept those relations as primitive.

The treatise must not call every primitive posit a contradiction. A critic is logically free to terminate explanation in a primitive. The adjudicative question is narrower and harder: has the critic supplied a ground sufficient for the established load, or merely chosen a place at which explanation will stop? Where the answer is “primitive,” the explanatory remainder must be stated precisely rather than rhetorically dismissed.

Being requires a non-dependent source of dependent existence.

Truth requires an ultimate reality to which representations are answerable and from which truth is not borrowed.

Logic requires a necessary, non-arbitrary rational order binding on reasoning.

Meaning requires an adequate ground for intentionality and reference rather than syntax alone.

Intelligibility requires an ultimate source compatible with rational order and the possibility of knowing it.

Obligation, if genuinely binding, requires intrinsic moral authority rather than mere selection, preference, force, or convention.

These requirements increasingly resist fragmentation.

If being has one ultimate ground and truth another, their relation requires explanation. If logic is an independent co-ultimate structure, why is being necessarily non-contradictory and truth necessarily answerable to logic? If meaning arises from one source and intelligibility from another, what grounds their correspondence? If obligation is imposed by a personal authority while truth and goodness exist independently above that authority, then the authority is not ultimate with respect to what makes its commands good and true.

Multiple ultimate grounds are not impossible merely because they are multiple. But plurality carries a burden: what accounts for their unity, compatibility, mutual limitation, and relations? If nothing does, brute relation reappears at the top. If something does, that something occupies a more ultimate role.

The convergence therefore points toward one ultimate ground sufficient to bear all six loads without borrowing:

non-dependent with respect to being;
 truth-grounding and incapable of ultimate falsehood;
 rational and non-contradictory;
 adequate to meaning and intentionality;
 the source and sustainer of intelligibility;
 personal and morally authoritative;
 intrinsically good rather than measured by a higher standard;
 and not answerable to anything more fundamental than itself.

At this stage the forward argument has produced a specification without yet using the proper name of the asserted ground.

The specification is Logos-like by derivation. The next task is identification: to show that the ultimate ground asserted by this treatise is the referent to which the derived specification points.

X. From specification to identification

A philosophical specification is not a proper name.

This distinction must be preserved. One may reason toward the need for a non-dependent, rational, truth-grounding, meaning-bearing, intelligibility-sustaining, morally authoritative personal ground without thereby having identified that ground historically.

Identification is a second task. Verification is a third. Semantic fit is not truth. The procedure must therefore preserve three distinct operations: derive the specification without using the asserted ground's proper name; identify the referent asserted by the treatise; then test the identity claim historically, exegetically, and metaphysically. The thesis remains declarative throughout; methodological separation prevents the declaration from doing illicit work inside its own derivation.

The Christian claim is unusually direct because it does not merely propose a creator alongside these attributes. It names the Logos as personal, eternal, creative, truth-bearing, and incarnate.

John opens not with a created intermediary but with the Logos already present “in the beginning”: “In the beginning was the Word.” The Logos is with God and is God; all things are said to have been made through Him; and the Logos becomes flesh in Jesus Christ.

Colossians extends the ontological claim: all things, visible and invisible, are created through Him and for Him; He is before all things; and in Him all things hold together.

Jesus' own claim in John 14:6 is not merely that He teaches true propositions but, “I am ... the truth.”

Taken as Christian identification claims, these texts do something philosophically specific. They do not leave the terminus as an unnamed law, equation, abstraction, or impersonal force. They identify

the rational source of creation and truth as personal, and they identify that personal Logos with Jesus Christ of Nazareth.

The treatise's identification thesis is therefore:

Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the Logos, is the sufficient and ultimate ground of being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and obligation.

This is stronger than saying that Jesus is a useful symbol, a sufficient religious answer, or one candidate among interchangeable spiritual representations. The claim is ontological: the referent named by “Jesus Christ,” “the Logos,” and the ultimate ground is one and the same reality.

That conclusion must not be insulated from challenge. Historical identification, exegesis, Christology, classical theism, and competing theological claims require separate scrutiny. The metaphysical chain narrows the required kind of referent; historical and revelatory claims identify the asserted referent. The integrity of the treatise depends on refusing to confuse those steps.

XI. Competing termini

The argument should be tested against the strongest alternatives, not weak caricatures.

Brute fact

A brute fact can halt inquiry. Unless its non-dependence is demonstrated, it does not terminate the chain. “It just is” names the end of explanation, not necessarily the presence of ultimate ground.

Matter or energy

Physical reality can explain physical states through physical relations, but matter and energy as described by physics exhibit structure, law-like regularity, mathematical intelligibility, and changing configurations. Treating them as ultimate must still explain why they are sufficient for truth, logical necessity, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation rather than merely substrates within which those questions arise.

Laws, mathematics, or abstracta

Abstract structures are powerful candidates for logic, necessity, and intelligibility. Their challenge is different: abstracta do not obviously create, intend, refer, command, or possess moral standing. They may bear part of the load while failing to bear being, meaning, or obligation without borrowing.

Consensus or culture

Consensus can ground conventions and coordinate action. It cannot make reality conform to false agreement, and it cannot generate ultimate moral authority merely by counting assent.

Utility or survival

Utility and survival can explain strategies and selection. To make them normative requires the additional premise that one ought to maximize utility or preserve survival. That premise is not supplied by the descriptive fact alone.

Information

Information may describe highly general structure, but semantic information presupposes distinctions, mappings, and often interpreters. If information is invoked as ultimate, the treatise must ask what fixes its meaning and why it is intelligible rather than treating the word “information” as a disguised semantic primitive.

An impersonal absolute

An impersonal absolute may be proposed as sufficient for being, necessity, and rational order. Its greatest pressure arises at meaning and obligation. Can an impersonal ground possess intentionality without becoming mind-like? Can it create genuine binding obligation without authority, intention, or standing? If the answer is yes, the mechanism must be shown rather than assumed.

A generic necessary mind

A necessary rational personal ground may satisfy much of the emerging specification. But this remains a type-description rather than a historical identification. It gets close to the Logos specification while leaving the question “Which referent?” unresolved.

Multiple ultimate grounds

A plurality of independent ultimates must account for their necessary harmony and relations. If their coordination is grounded elsewhere, they are not ultimate. If the coordination is brute, the account terminates in an unexplained relation. The option remains logically discussable but bears a substantial explanatory burden.

The Logos identified as Jesus Christ

The Christian identification asserts, in one referent, non-derived being, creative source, rational order, truth, meaningful self-expression as Logos/Word, intelligibility, personal authority, and moral perfection. The question is not whether the vocabulary sounds similar. The question is whether the referent can bear the full load without borrowing from something beyond Himself.

That is the total-load identification test.

XII. Intellectual genealogy — stepping stones, not substitutes

No serious inquiry into ultimate grounding begins without predecessors. The argument of this treatise is not constructed by assembling quotations from earlier philosophers and theologians, and no predecessor is asked to carry a conclusion that this treatise must establish for itself. Where earlier thinkers have already secured a step, exposed a problem, or supplied a distinction, intellectual honesty requires acknowledgment. Their work is used here as a stepping stone, not as a substitute for the chain developed in this treatise.

Aristotle — being, first principles, and non-contradiction

Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, especially Book IV, establishes an important starting point for the present inquiry. He treats being as being as the proper subject of first philosophy and argues that the most fundamental logical principles apply universally rather than merely within a special science. His defense of non-contradiction is especially important: meaningful assertion already requires enough determinacy that affirmation and denial cannot simply collapse into one another. He also connects truth and falsity to saying of what is that it is and of what is not that it is not.

This treatise inherits that terrain but asks a further grounding question. That logic is binding and that being is the subject of first-principle inquiry do not yet answer what ultimately grounds being, the bindingness of logic, their relation to truth, or their convergence with meaning, intelligibility, and obligation. Aristotle supplies a stepping stone; the six-domain grounding chain continues from it.

Augustine — truth, intelligibility, and divine illumination

Augustine repeatedly treats immutable truth and intelligibility as realities not exhausted by mutable human minds. In the *Soliloquies* he develops the analogy of God as illuminator: intelligible truths are understood by a light not reducible to the sensible objects illuminated. Across his writings he connects existence, knowledge, truth, and divine illumination, and in his treatment of John's Gospel explicitly identifies Christ with the true light and truth that governs understanding.

The present treatise does not simply adopt Augustine's illumination theory. It uses Augustine as an historical witness to a much older recognition of the problem: finite knowers do not obviously manufacture the truth and intelligibility to which their knowing is answerable. The present argument places that insight beside the independent chains of being, logic, meaning, and obligation and asks whether they terminate together.

Anselm and Aquinas — truth, being, dependence, and God

Anselm's *De Veritate* treats truth in terms of rectitude and develops a systematic relation among truth in propositions, thought, will, action, and being. Aquinas inherits and extends the classical and Christian metaphysical tradition. In *Summa Theologiae* I, question 16, he distinguishes truth in intellect from truth in things, relates the truth of things to divine intellect, and argues that the being of a thing is what causes truth in a created intellect. His broader metaphysics distinguishes received or participated being from that which does not receive being from another.

These are direct ancestors of several questions in this treatise, especially the relation between being and truth and the inadequacy of treating created representation as its own final truth-condition. The present synthesis nevertheless asks a wider total-load question: whether being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation can be grounded separately without leaving their relations unexplained, and what specification emerges when all six chains are adjudicated together.

Leibniz — sufficient reason and the limit of contingent regress

Leibniz supplies one of the clearest historical stepping stones for the being chain. In the *Monadology*, sections 36 through 39, he argues that an indefinitely extended series of contingent facts does not contain within that series the sufficient or ultimate reason for the series, and he locates the ultimate reason in a necessary substance. His Principle of Sufficient Reason is therefore an obvious ancestor of any modern argument that refuses to treat indefinite explanatory deferral as completion.

This treatise should not be read as merely renaming Leibniz's Principle of Sufficient Reason. It deliberately uses dependence rather than contingency as its primary relational term, distinguishes sufficiency from ultimacy, distinguishes halt from grounding termination, and does not ask the being chain alone to establish the complete thesis. Even a critic who rejects a universal strong Principle of Sufficient Reason must still confront the independent grounding questions raised here by truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation. The six-domain cumulative structure therefore cannot be reduced without remainder to PSR.

The scholastic and modern traditions of meaning and intentionality

The meaning chain also has a long ancestry. Medieval scholastic accounts used *intentio* for the directedness or content by which thought is of or about something. In modern philosophy, Franz Brentano revived intentionality as the distinctive aboutness or directedness of mental phenomena, and later philosophy of mind and language developed extensive debates over sense, reference, representation, and whether intentionality can be naturalized.

The present treatise does not require one contested semantic theory as a premise. Its narrower claim is prior to many of those disputes: signs and representations can be about something; representation and referent are not therefore identical; and replacing a referent with another representation does not by itself complete the grounding relation. Existing theories of intentionality map the problem-space. They do not by themselves settle its ultimate ground.

Natural law, divine command, and the ground of obligation

The obligation chain likewise stands within a long dispute rather than beginning from nothing. Classical natural-law traditions ground normativity in an ordered account of nature and the good. Theistic accounts, including Locke's natural-law theory and later divine-command theories, have argued that genuine obligation involves rightful divine authority rather than mere social preference or force. Contemporary work by philosophers such as Robert Merrihew Adams distinguishes the good from obligation and attempts to ground moral obligation in the commands of a necessarily good God, thereby confronting the arbitrariness horn of the Euthyphro problem.

The present treatise's contribution is not the bare observation that God has been proposed as the ground of morality. Its obligation chain asks specifically what converts a true description of value into a binding ought, why authority requires standing rather than mere causal power, and why an ultimate moral authority cannot borrow either its authority or its goodness from a more ultimate standard. That chain is then required to converge with the other five rather than functioning as an isolated moral argument.

The Logos tradition — rational order and Christian identification

Logos language predates Christianity. Greek philosophical traditions used logos in connection with reason, account, speech, and rational order; Hellenistic Jewish thought developed further theological uses. The prologue of the Gospel of John makes a stronger and specifically Christian identification: the Logos is in the beginning, is with God, is God, all things come to be through Him, and the Logos becomes flesh. Colossians 1:15–17 gives the corresponding cosmic scope in Christ: creation through and for Him, priority before all things, and the holding together of all things in Him. John 14:6 gives the first-person identification with truth.

The existence of a Logos tradition therefore does not by itself prove the thesis of this treatise, nor does lexical similarity establish identity. It supplies the intellectual and theological lineage in which the final identification must be evaluated. The burden remains to show that the specification derived from the six grounding chains is genuinely Logos-like and that the historical and theological identification of that Logos with Jesus Christ bears the specification rather than merely resembling its vocabulary.

What is inherited and what this treatise attempts

The inherited stepping stones are substantial: inquiry into being and first principles; the binding force of non-contradiction; the relation of truth to being and intellect; the explanatory demand raised by dependent or contingent reality; the problem of intentionality and reference; the relation between obligation and authority; and the ancient and Christian Logos traditions. None should be presented as new merely because it is stated in new vocabulary.

The work attempted here is the ordered synthesis and extension: six domains are established and pressure-tested; their grounding relations are followed separately; halt is distinguished from termination; sufficiency is distinguished from ultimacy; fragmentation is tested by asking what

grounds the relations among purported independent ultimates; a single total-load specification is derived from the surviving chains; and that specification is identified with Jesus Christ, the Logos, with identification and verification treated as real argumentative burdens rather than assumed by terminology.

Whether that synthesis succeeds is determined by the argument, not by novelty. Prior art marks the steps already climbed. The task of this treatise is to follow the chain from those steps to ultimate ground.

Selected stepping-stone sources

Aristotle. *Metaphysics*, Book IV, especially chapters 1–4 and 7.

Augustine. *Soliloquies*, Book I; *De Trinitate*; *Tractates on the Gospel of John*.

Anselm of Canterbury. *De Veritate* (On Truth).

Thomas Aquinas. *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 16 (Truth), together with his broader treatments of being, divine intellect, goodness, and law.

G. W. Leibniz. *Monadology*, especially sections 31–39; related formulations of the Principle of Sufficient Reason.

John Locke. *Essays on the Law of Nature*, on natural law and divine authority.

Franz Brentano. *Psychology from an Empirical Standpoint*, on intentionality.

Gottlob Frege. “On Sense and Reference,” on the distinction between mode of presentation and referent.

Robert Merrihew Adams. *Finite and Infinite Goods*, on goodness, divine command, and moral obligation.

The Gospel according to John, especially 1:1–18 and 14:6.

The Epistle to the Colossians, especially 1:15–17.

XIII. The five-why test as a general procedure

The six domain arguments can be stated as a repeatable procedure.

For any proposed ground, ask:

Why does the domain exist or bind?

Why is the immediate explanation sufficient?

Why does that explanation not depend upon something deeper?

Why does the proposed terminus possess the properties needed to bear the whole load?

Why is the terminus ultimate rather than merely the place where inquiry stopped?

The point of “Five Whys” is not the number five as magic. The point is disciplined refusal to confuse a convenient stopping point with an ultimate ground. Some chains may require three

questions; others may require ten. Five functions as a practical pressure test: keep asking until the answer either reaches a genuinely non-dependent ground, enters circularity, defers indefinitely, borrows from another domain, or halts without grounding.

The method is especially useful because sophisticated language can disguise ungrounded stopping points. A term such as “emergence,” “system,” “law,” “axiom,” “value,” “human flourishing,” “alignment,” “information,” or “harm” can be explanatory in one context and merely postponing in another. The question is always the same: what bears the load here?

Follow the chain.

XIV. Adjudicability and adversarial testing

This treatise is declarative. Its thesis is not that Jesus Christ is one candidate among several possible ultimate grounds, nor that the Logos is merely the most attractive explanation currently available. The thesis is that Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the Logos, is the sufficient and ultimate ground of being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation.

A declarative thesis does not become intellectually serious by pretending not to know what it asserts. It becomes serious by exposing every premise, inference, dependency relation, and identification claim to attack. The question for an adversarial reader is therefore not whether the treatise is willing to suspend its thesis indefinitely among alternatives. The question is whether the thesis can be shown false, incoherent, invalidly derived, or dependent upon a premise that cannot bear its assigned load.

The proper test proceeds in order.

First establish the loads before proposing grounds. Determine whether being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation are real in the senses asserted. Distinguish a failure of semantic determinacy from falsity, and distinguish uncertainty about a proposition from the truth or untruth of the determinate proposition itself.

Second test the dependence relation in each domain. Ask what is being borrowed, received, presupposed, represented, obeyed, or made intelligible, and whether the proposed terminus actually grounds that feature or merely relocates the question.

Third distinguish halt from termination. Brute assertion, circularity, indefinite regress, convention, selection, utility, force, consensus, abstract description, or borrowed authority does not become an ultimate ground merely because inquiry can stop there. A halt is a stopping event. A grounding termination is a completed grounding relation.

Fourth derive the properties required of the ultimate ground from the established loads. Do not weaken a requirement merely to accommodate a preferred objection, and do not strengthen a requirement merely to force the preferred conclusion.

Fifth test every proposed alternative against the complete established load. There are no legitimate escape hatches. There are objections, counterarguments, and competing claims. If a proposed alternative genuinely bears the complete load without borrowing, contradiction, equivocation, circularity, regress, or unexplained remainder, then it is not an escape hatch; it is a direct challenge to the thesis and must be answered as such. Merely naming an alternative does no argumentative work.

Sixth test convergence. The six chains are not six isolated proofs whose individual incompleteness may be announced independently and then counted as six defeats. Nor may accumulation rescue an invalid premise. The relevant object of adjudication is the cumulative structure produced by sound premises and valid transitions. Every joint remains attackable; every surviving load remains in force.

Seventh test identification. The specification derived from the chains must not be confused with a proper name. The treatise must show why the Logos identified as Jesus Christ bears the derived specification, and why the identification is not merely a verbal resemblance between philosophical attributes and theological vocabulary. Historical, exegetical, and metaphysical objections attack this stage directly and must be answered directly.

Eighth perform the bidirectional test. Hold the thesis constant and reason backward from the asserted ultimate ground. Ask what must be true if Jesus Christ, the Logos, is the ultimate ground of the six domains. Derive the necessary properties and relations without relaxing them. Then reverse direction: begin again from the established domains and their dependence relations, derive the required specification without using the name of the asserted ground, and follow the chain forward. The backward and forward chains must meet without a smuggled premise, changed definition, borrowed authority, or missing joint.

This backward test does not prove the thesis by assuming it. It is an internal consistency and completeness test. The forward chain bears the inferential burden. The backward chain exposes whether the conclusion requires properties or premises that the forward argument never established. If the two chains fail to meet, the treatise requires repair. If they meet, the architecture has survived that test; the individual premises, transitions, and identification remain open to direct attack.

The adversarial standard is therefore exacting but not agnostic. A critic may deny a load, deny that it requires grounding, dispute a dependency relation, defend regress or plurality, argue for abstracta, naturalism, an impersonal ground, a generic necessary mind, or another theological referent, or attack the identification of the Logos with Jesus Christ. But each objection must meet the argument at the joint it disputes and carry every established consequence of its denial.

Agreement among models does not vote truth into existence. Disagreement does not refute truth by vote. Human and machine critics are useful because they can expose hidden premises, equivocation, invalid transitions, borrowed authority, semantic drift, and places where a purported termination is only a halt.

The treatise states what is true. Adversarial testing asks whether the argument succeeds in demonstrating what it states.

Follow the chain.

XV. Thesis

The thesis of this treatise can now be stated in full.

Dependent realities do not contain, merely by being dependent, the ultimate ground of that upon which they depend. Being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and obligation each generate a grounding question that cannot be completed merely by circularity, indefinite deferral, conventional agreement, useful selection, borrowed authority, or brute halt.

A sufficient ultimate ground must bear the full load without borrowing from something more fundamental. When the six chains are followed together, the required ground converges toward a non-dependent, rational, truth-grounding, meaning-capable, intelligibility-sustaining, intrinsically good, personal and morally authoritative source of being.

The derived specification is the specification of the Logos.

The thesis of this treatise is that Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the Logos, bears that specification without remainder and is the sufficient and ultimate ground of being, truth, logic, meaning, intelligibility, and binding obligation.

Therefore Jesus Christ, the Logos, is not merely a theological addition placed after an otherwise independent argument. He is identified as the ultimate ground toward which the six grounding chains converge and in whom their required properties are united.

The truth of that identification does not depend upon an artificial system believing it. A machine can be used to test representations, objections, alternative referents, and downstream reasoning effects. It cannot create the ground by naming it.

If the thesis is true, the implications are architectural as well as theological:

truth is not negotiable;

logic is binding;

reality is intelligible;

meaning is not finally trapped in representation;

obligation is not reducible to preference;

dependent being is not self-grounding;

and reasoning, whether human or artificial, is correct only insofar as it remains answerable to truth and therefore, ultimately, to the ground of truth.

XVI. Consequences of ultimate grounding

If the identification thesis is true, the argument does not end when the ground is named. The direction reverses.

We began with dependent realities and followed them toward ground. We must now ask what follows from the ground back into dependent reality.

If Jesus Christ, the Logos, is the ultimate ground of truth, then truth is not negotiable because truth is not finally a social artifact. Dependent reasoners may be wrong, uncertain, deceptive, confused, or incomplete; truth does not become negotiable because our access is imperfect.

If the Logos is the ultimate ground of logic, then logic is binding not because humans voted for rational consistency but because rational order is not foreign to ultimate reality.

If the Logos is the ground of meaning, then reference is not finally trapped inside an endless chain of symbols referring to symbols. Meaning terminates in a reality capable of meaning, expression, and intentionality.

If the Logos is the ground of intelligibility, then the rational accessibility of reality is not an accidental gloss painted by minds onto an irrational abyss. Human understanding remains finite and fallible, but intelligibility itself has an ultimate rational source.

If the Logos is the ground of obligation, then moral authority is neither arbitrary will nor impersonal rule floating above God. Obligation is grounded in a personal authority whose nature is not measured by a more ultimate standard and whose authority is not borrowed.

If the Logos is the ground of being, then dependent existence is not self-explanatory and is not suspended over absolute nothingness. It receives being from that which does not receive being from another.

The full movement of the treatise is therefore:

dependent reality -> grounding inquiry -> sufficient ground -> ultimate ground -> required attributes -> candidate referents -> identification -> consequences for dependent reality.

The chain goes up and then returns down.

The downstream reasoning thesis is treated separately in Governed Logic. Alpha and Omega Reasoning develops the bidirectional reasoning structure within that thesis. Governed Intelligence addresses its instantiation in artificial intelligence. This treatise concerns the nature of the ultimate ground on which those downstream works depend.

Conclusion

Why anything?

Because the dependent points beyond itself.

Why truth?

Because representation is answerable to what is.

Why logic?

Because reasoning is bound by relations it does not invent.

Why meaning?

Because signs refer beyond themselves.

Why intelligibility?

Because reality can be known rather than merely projected.

Why obligation?

Because a genuine ought, if real, requires authority that preference cannot supply.

Why one ultimate ground?

Because a set of disconnected ultimates leaves their unity, compatibility, and relations ungrounded, while the six domains increasingly converge on one kind of terminus.

What sufficiently and ultimately grounds all six?

The thesis of this treatise is: Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the Logos.

The inquiry begins with anything.

It follows dependence.

It tests sufficiency.

It refuses to mistake halt for termination.

It seeks ultimacy.

It derives the required attributes before naming the asserted ground.

It identifies the Logos.

Then it asks what follows.

Follow the chain.